

SCENE O

AN EMPTY BLOCK

After attending the retirement party of their pre-K teacher, PEG/I walks home and talks to AMBROSE/IA on their AirPods. They carry a briefcase. They soon walk by their former run-down school.

PEG/I

Ms. Ngo. She shaped up to be a great teacher. We're lucky to have been in her first class.

AMBROSE/IA (PHONE)

A decade is just too quick for a retirement...

PEG/I

Middle-age retirement parties are so in.

AMBROSE/IA (PHONE)

No one but us went!

PEG/I

The invite list was a slip of paper.

AMBROSE/IA (PHONE)

By the way, *who slipped away with her briefcase?* She has been frantically texting the group chat.

PEG/I

I don't know.

AMBROSE/IA (PHONE)

It's not me.

PEG/I

Ms. Ngo can live without it.

AMBROSE/IA (PHONE)

You and I always had very different experience with her.

PEG/I

She can be such a square.

AMBROSE/IA (PHONE)

(Mockingly)

She hasn't changed. Remember when she'd be like: "*Peg/i, don't hop on the squares!*"

PEG/I

She was so weird about us playing hopscotch.

AMBROSE/IA (PHONE)

(Mockingly)

Oh, it's against her lord and savior, Buddha.

PEG/I

She had a better sense of keeping religion out of public schools more than most teachers in this country.

AMBROSE/IA (PHONE)

Where are you in this country?

PEG/I

Is this another riddle?

AMBROSE/IA (PHONE)

No. Have you gotten home yet?

PEG/I

Almost.

The hopscotch is in sight. Peg/i towers over the ominous and anomalous chalk on the road.

Peg/i sets their briefcase on the ground. They open it. The briefcase holds a single stone which is societally insignificant but the whole world to Peg/i.

PEG/I (CONT'D)

It only took ten years.

AMBROSE/IA (PHONE)

Ten years to get home? Did you move out to Flushing without telling me?

PEG/I

My attempts were flushed down the tube going to this school, but today will be different.

AMBROSE/IA (PHONE)

Wait, where-? Whatcha doing visiting our elementary school?!

PEG/I

I was on the fence. Since then, I vaulted hurdles. I jumped guns. I will hop these squares!

AMBROSE/IA (PHONE)

(Mockingly)

Oh no... Ms. Ngo is not gonna like this.

PEG/I

Too bad, she's not here!

Peg/i tosses the rock on the first square.

MS. NGO (OFFSTAGE)
(Echoing)

Peg/i....!

PEG/I

Did you hear that?

AMBROSE/IA (PHONE)

Uh, I admit it. You're hearing me put square
pegs in the wrong holes.

PEG/I

Ew- Damn, Ambrose/ia. You get it.

AMBROSE/IA (PHONE)

And you best not get...

Peg/i jumps on each square. With
each hop erupts echoes of warnings
and children's laughters.

AMBROSE/IA (CONT'D)

Yourself into trouble.

MS. NGO (OFFSTAGE)

You are in trouble!

Peg/i reaches the semi-circle of
the hopscotch. They fall into
another plane of existence.

SCENE □

NOWHERE BLOCK

MS. NGO is in the darkness trying
to put a literal square peg in a
round hole of a toy. There is
something off about her.

MS. NGO

Peg... Peg... Peg...

PEG/I

Ms. Ngo?

MS. NGO

Oh no... You completed the hopscotch?

PEG/I

Is this what you're in? What're you doing here?

MS. NGO
(Insanely)

Nowhere else have I felt so whole.

PEG/I

You know you could have moved to Florida like every retiree. For a messed-up place, at least it has some beaches!

MS. NGO

I retired? Never will I retire.

PEG/I

You've been only teaching for ten years. You really shouldn't.

MS. NGO

Sweetie. It's still student teaching. It's my first year.

PEG/I

Do you recognize me?

MS. NGO

Do you happen to be Peg/i's older sibling?

PEG/I

You're looking at Peg/i.

MS. NGO

It can't be!

PEG/I

(Throwing themself in a loop)

Who is the Ms. Ngo that I know?

MS. NGO

That Ms. Ngo you've known has been a misnomer.

PEG/I

This has sure rocked my world.

MS. NGO notices the rock
illuminating on the ground.

MS. NGO

My stone... It is an ancient liminal stone that has warped spacetime. And you placed its roundness into the chalked up square. This is the only way to our salvation.

AN EMPTY BLOCK

PEG/I is lying on the ground,
dazed. The hopscotch is now
scribbles.

AMBROSE/IA's shadow towers PEG/I.

AMBROSE/IA
Peg/i?! Get off the chalk!

Fin